



Sea turtles

Most marine animals breed at sea, but sea turtles must come ashore to nest. They select warm, sandy, remote beaches where the female turtles can haul themselves out of the water easily, dig holes in the sand, and bury their eggs. The warm sand incubates the eggs, and when the young hatch they make their way back to the sea. Here, they feed on marine life including shrimp and jellyfish, as well as seaweeds and seagrasses. The turtles may travel vast distances across oceans, especially when returning to their home beaches to breed.

Leatherback sea turtle

Biggest turtle on Earth

Length Up to 118 in (300 cm)

Range All warm and temperate oceans

Diet Jellyfish

The biggest sea turtle is the giant leatherback, which gets its name from the leathery skin that covers its ridged shell—unlike other turtles, its shell is not made of tough keratin. The leatherback's body is highly streamlined,

enabling it to swim vast distances with little effort. It is specialized for eating jellyfish; its throat is lined with fleshy, downward-pointing spikes to ensure its slippery victims cannot escape.



Olive ridley sea turtle

Mass breeder

Length Up to 28 in (70 cm)

Range Mainly Pacific and Indian oceans

Diet Fish, jellyfish, clams, and prawns

This small sea turtle starts life with a grayish heart-shaped shell that eventually changes to an olive green color. Although they prefer to live alone, hundreds and sometimes even thousands of females return en masse to the beaches where they hatched to lay their eggs in the sand.

